

Episode 201: About *Revolutionary Girl Utena* – Part 3

Now then.

For *Utena*'s character colour design work, through Copic colouring + cut-and-paste decisions, main characters were gradually determined.

First I roughly met with Ikuhara, and for key parts Ikuhara would indicate colour images, while for other character colours I'd first place colours and everyone would give opinions to decide - we started with that approach.

Protagonist Utena's pink hair colour was Ikuhara's image from the beginning (I learnt later that initially in Saito Chiho's manga, Utena had proceeded with blonde hair + red uniform, but from when I participated at the anime production stage she proceeded with pink hair). For eye colour I made them emerald for balance with the hair. Was this also Ikuhara's? My image? The male student's high-collar uniform that Utena wears initially had "red" and "white" options, and we tried painting each as tests, but since "it feels too 'princely'" we headed toward another "black" option. Furthermore, there was verification back-and-forth with Ikuhara about "Is the same black okay for uniform and duel outfit (duelist)?" We tried various things here too and settled on "black."

After deciding to go with "black," next came decisions about how to show "black." Whether to use normal animation balance of normal part + shadow, or normal (no shadow) with highlight animation. Going with "normal part + shadow" means shadow parts become black (BL) but normal parts become slightly brighter colours like grey or blue. Then in wide shots (long shots showing full body) shadow parts become small and the "black" impression weakens. With "normal (no shadow) with highlight" style, omitting highlights in wide shots leaves it as straight "black." So "This one!" and we decided on the current style. Furthermore, Hasegawa's modifications to decorative items (shoulder rope-like things, etc.) were added for completion.

Since we made Utena's uniform "black," other male students were decided as "white." We tried other colours like black and dark navy, but with a "well, naturally" feeling, white top with green pants. It was decided quite smoothly with the colour design matching for girls' uniforms. Oh, the girls' uniforms should be almost exactly as initially designed.

Chu-Chu was... I think that stayed the same from the initial colour?

"Ikuhara, is this a monkey? A mouse?" I asked.

"Well, I don't know!" said Ikuhara (laugh).

So it became a colour that could be taken either way.

Incidentally, when that mysterious creature appeared in the "theatrical version":

"Is this a crocodile? What is it?" I asked.

"Well, I have absolutely no idea!" said Kaneko (laugh).

And it became like that.

For student council members, it was decided to determine theme colours for each - Touga's "red," Juri's "orange," Miki's "blue," and Saionji's "green" were almost initial images. Initially I remember Touga's hair being solid colour without mesh. When I coloured it and brought it, it became "somehow ordinary," so we divided the front hair into a lock with mesh-like colouring and it became "This is it!" Everything else - skin, hair, eyes - was decided quite smoothly, but what wasn't decided until the end was the student council members' uniforms.

For the top, it was decided the jacket base colour would be "white" and each character would have pants in their theme colours, but then in bust shots everyone would have white uniforms, and each theme colour feeling would be weak. "Couldn't we think of design that puts 'colour' in the top half too?" So various trial and error began. Adding division lines to the front for more colour divisions, cleanly changing just sleeves from the shoulders, modifications and reviews not just of colour but design itself began. But we didn't want to break the basic line of navy military uniform-like design form. Without good ideas emerging, meetings continued.

"We need to reach conclusions and FIX things soon." I think the deadline for publicly releasing the work's visuals in magazines was approaching. But while it had generally come together nicely, that day too no decisive blow emerged. "Well then, let me try modifying the colour division animation myself," I said and had them entrust it to me. A few days later, I brought the Tsujita proposal to BE-PAPAS.

"Let's go with this, this!" What I presented was a version with only one sleeve - just from the elbow down - outlined and coloured with gold lines. After considering various options, this felt most like it. As a result it was adopted as-is. The student council members were complete.

And then Anthy. Anthy's brown skin colour was in Ikuhara's image from the beginning. If we made it too dark and emphasised racial feeling too much, it might become problematic, so we carefully decided on a balanced tone. By giving Anthy that skin tone, we could create a good balance of feeling different from normal and mysterious.

Speaking of Anthy, there's that wedding dress as "Rose Bride." Initially I tried placing colours with an ordinary "white" wedding dress. Brown skin with pure white wedding dress... but it was ordinary. So I boldly tried painting it bright red. We need this much impact! Thinking that, I brought that "red" version.

"Red!"

Even Ikuhara seemed this was unexpected, walking around the studio occasionally saying "red." Then after a while, Ikuhara was making a phone call somewhere. His usual long phone call mode. In that call he was talking about "Rose Bride." He seemed to be persuading someone he wanted to go with "red." That person was Saito Chiho. Thus Anthy's "Rose Bride" became a bright red dress.

Time flows to this year (2013) spring. "Revolutionary Girl Utena Exhibition" was held in Tokyo's Ikebukuro. What a feeling of "well, it survived!" - displayed rough animation, cels, licencing art and others, a tremendous number of materials from that time. In the centre of that venue filled with those materials, that dress was there. Yes, Anthy's "Rose Bride" bright red dress. It was a real Anthy dress made by Nasuka-san, who also created *Mawaru Penguindrum's* penguin plushies and such.

It was truly real - recreating the dress that appeared in the story exactly in the real world. That dress's presence standing resolute in the centre of the venue! Perfect workmanship that evoked the moment when dress owner Princess Anthy had just vanished this instant, leaving only the dress she wore behind.

When considering colours in anime, what I'm constantly concerned about is "what kind of texture is it?" Naturally the texture of Anthy's bridal costume in my mind was silk. But if you think in realistic texture, the assertiveness becomes poor when put on screen. So rather than silk, I deliberately swung the colour tone development to flashy red like satin. Utena's "black," Anthy's "red."

On *Revolutionary Girl Utena's* screen, there was no "red" other than that red that wouldn't lose to Utena's "black." But in my mind that bridal costume was silk, and the dress texture actually in my mind was different from that screen's red. So encountering that bridal costume at that venue was shocking. Ah, this is it! I was simply incredibly happy. "It's real Anthy with just the contents missing." Surrounded by production materials as "past," that dress standing brilliantly in the centre was the only "new" thing transcending time.

(13.11.22)